

VERITY TRAVEL

The Smart Cruise Planning Checklist

*Everything worth thinking through before you book —
the same questions we walk every client through.*

Travel, Thoughtfully Planned

Before You Start

Cruising has more moving parts than people expect — cabin category, itinerary timing, deposit and cancellation terms, insurance, embarkation logistics. This checklist walks through the decisions worth making deliberately, in the order they usually come up. Work through it before you book, or send it to us and we'll do the legwork for you.

1. Set Your Trip Foundations

- Decide who's traveling and confirm everyone's passport is valid 6+ months past your return date.
- Set a total budget — including gratuities, excursions, drink packages, and travel insurance, not just the cruise fare.
- Choose your season and region based on weather, crowd levels, and pricing, not just availability.
Shoulder-season sailings often mean better weather-to-price ratios than peak weeks.
- Decide how many sea days vs. port days you actually want.

2. Choose the Right Ship & Cabin

- Match the cruise line's onboard personality to your group — party-forward, family-focused, or adults-only quiet.
- Pick a cabin category deliberately: interior, oceanview, balcony, or suite.
A balcony is worth it on scenic itineraries (Alaska, Norway); less so on Caribbean island-hopping routes.
- Check the deck plan for noise sources near your cabin — above the theater, below the pool deck, near elevators.
- Confirm connecting or adjoining cabins now if traveling with family — these sell out first.

3. Understand the Money Details

- Read the deposit amount and refund deadline before you pay it.
- Check the final payment date and put it on your calendar — missed payments can cancel a booking.
- Decide on travel insurance and buy it within the window that covers pre-existing conditions if relevant.
- Ask what's included vs. add-on: gratuities, WiFi, drink packages, and specialty dining are rarely all included.

4. Handle the Logistics

- Book flights that arrive at least one day before embarkation — never fly in same-day.
- Arrange pre- or post-cruise hotel nights if arriving early or extending the trip.
- Check visa requirements for every port country, not just your embarkation port.
- Register your cruise line's app and complete online check-in as soon as it opens.

5. Plan Onboard & Ashore

- Book specialty dining and popular excursions as soon as booking opens — these sell out weeks in advance.
- Decide ship-sponsored vs. independent excursions.
Independent tours are often cheaper, but the ship waits for its own excursions if one runs late — it won't wait for yours.
- Pack for both formal nights and shore excursions — layers matter more than people expect.
- Set a daily onboard spending plan so incidentals don't surprise you at checkout.

Want someone to run this list for you instead? That's the job. Reach out at hello@veritytravels.com or through veritytravels.com and we'll build your itinerary from here.